On the origin of functions by means of natural selection and other processes

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ABSTRACT

I at least try to write my paper before I write my abstract, because I hardly ever know what to summarize before I've written it. This in itself is most likey to be seen as a shortcoming, but be that as it may.

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If we are to believe Amie L. Thomasson, then many ontological and metaphysical theories have passed their best-before dates. Her arguments are that current ontologies is far too complex (Thomasson, 2016) and that metaphysics itself is basically broken (Thomasson, 2026), and that it therefore must be made *functional* again. By functional she does not mean that someone should repair metaphysics but that the old quinean ontologies should be retired. In metaphysics entities should be studied based on their functions. Not their properties. What Quine actually wrote is

> a theory is [ontologically] committed to those and only those entities to which the bound variables of the theory must be capable of referring in order that the affirmations made in the theory be true (Quine, 1948).

Another way to think of this would be to choose ones study objects based on whether they are amenable to first order logic.

Following Quine's seminal paper, philosophers started to interest themselves in metaphysical issues after the low-water mark after the onslaught of the Vienna school and the positivists. During the following renaissance metaphysicians studied explanatory power of entities and concepts, their structures, truthmakers and fundamentality and grounding (Thomasson, 2025).

It would be to go far beyond the scope of this text to review those various metaphysical disciplines; rather we go directly to Thomasson's preferred road forward, which is the functional approach strengthened with conceptual engineering (Thomasson, 2025, p. 103–131).

References

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